





and taste the thrill of non-national partisan support; sporting ecosystems are evolving for the better as a result.

Take the recently concluded Prime Volleyball League (PVB). A brainchild of Tuhin Mishra, CEO and managing director of Baseline Ventures, a sports marketing, entertainment and brand management company which represents the likes of P.V. Sindhu and Smriti Mandhana, PVB has ensured that one of the biggest team sports in the world in terms of fanbase gets a push in India. "Volleyball has a mix of urban and rural appeal [in India]. It's not an expensive sport to play, is easy to follow and looks good on screen, for it is very fast-moving and action-oriented," says Mishra. With 10 teams in the fourth edition, 24 foreign players from volleyball-rich nations such as the US, Brazil, Iran and Serbia, coaches like the US's David Lee, an Olympic and world championship medallist, and the backing of solid sponsors and team owners, PVB has demonstrated how sustaining a league benefits the sport.

The result is obvious—the Indian men's team's world ranking has risen to the top 50 from 131 since the league's launch in 2019. For many, India's beating higher-ranked teams like South Korea and Chinese Taipei to reach the quarter-finals of the 2022 Asian Games for the first time in 40 years can be attributed to the quality of PVB. An equally big feat was 2024 PVB champions Calicut Heroes winning the CAVA (Central Asian Volleyball Association) Club Championship. Such results and the fact that the league has become a hunting ground to scout players for the India team are what motivates Mishra. His dream is to see India make it to the Olympics. "With the existing roadmap, if we act right and get support, there's a strong chance that we will qualify for the 2032 Games," he says.